Retail Magnate

IT WAS IN 2014 THAT ISHA AMBANI took on a management role in group businesses at Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL), India's largest private sector company. Both Isha and her twin brother Akash then joined the relatively new-age businesses of the group, Reliance Jio Infocomm and Reliance Retail Ventures, as directors at the age of 24, the same age their father Mukesh Ambani was when he joined his father Dhirubhai Ambani's business in 1981. Isha, who graduated from Yale University with majors in psychology and South Asian studies in 2013, had a brief stint with McKinsey in the US before joining the family business. She later completed her MBA from Stanford University in 2018. Isha is married to childhood friend and now businessman Anand Piramal, son of industrialist Ajay Piramal and Dr Swati Piramal.

During the pandemic, while Mukesh stitched some significant business deals, Isha found it the perfect learning ground to hone her skills. Both she and Akash were key negotiators in mega deals that Jio Platforms, RIL's digital arm, struck with the likes of Google, Facebook and Intel in a bid to turn the group into a futuristic enterprise. Isha was also involved in all big acquisitions by Jio Platforms, including Den Networks, Hathway Cable and Datacom. This October, she got the role shareholders had been long anticipating—her appointment, along with Akash and their younger brother Anant, on the board of RIL.

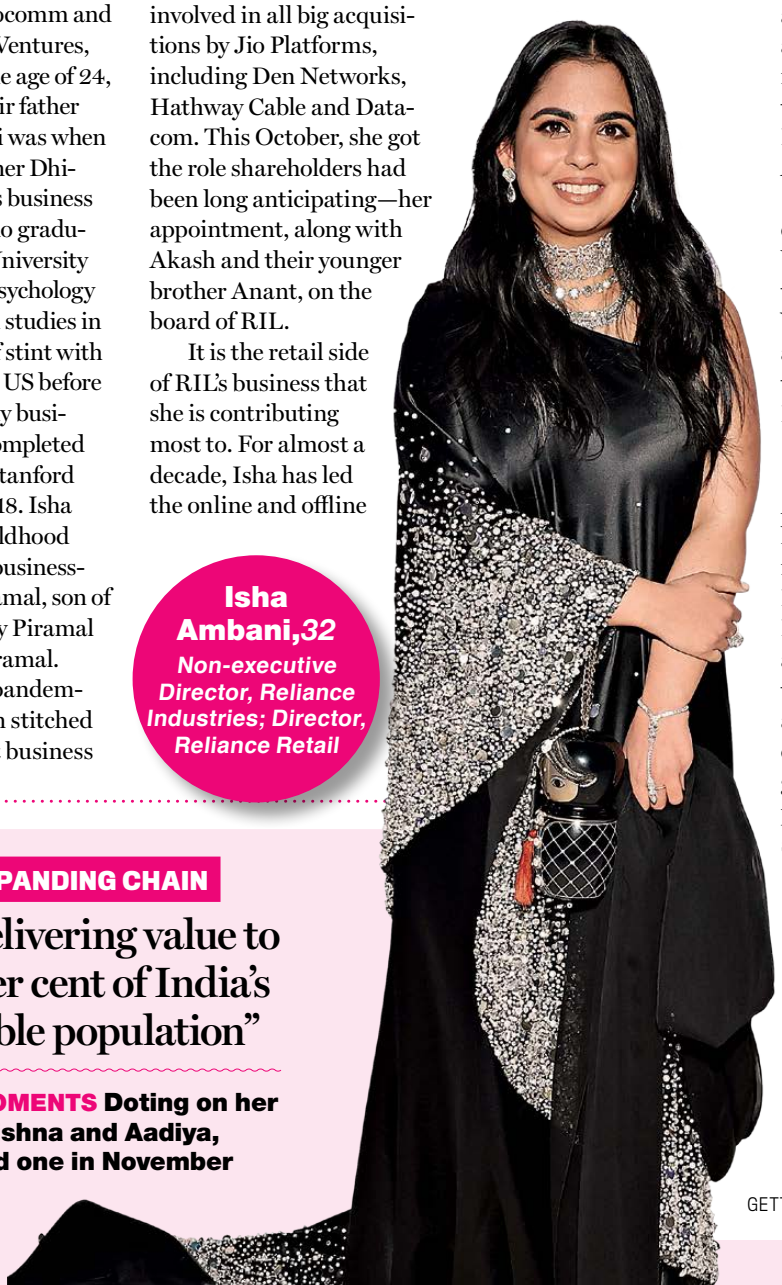
It is the retail side of RIL's business that she is contributing most to. For almost a decade, Isha has led the online and offline business of Reliance Retail, India's largest retailer by revenue, profit, reach and scale. The firm—the only Indian entity in the global 100 top retailers—reported a revenue of Rs 2.6 lakh crore in FY23, a 30 per cent jump over the previous fiscal. "We opened over 3,300 new stores last year, taking the total count to 18,040 stores, covering 65.6 million sq. ft of retail space. Two-thirds of these stores are in Tier II, Tier III cities and smaller towns, a testament to our commitment to making retail inclusive," Isha said at the company's AGM in August this year.

Isha's responsibilities extend beyond the realm of business as well. She is on the advisory board of the Yale Schwarzman Center and the board of trustees at the Smithsonian's National Museum of Asian Art, the Mumbai Academy of Moving Image and the Dia Art Foundation. Besides leading the art and culture initiatives undertaken by Reliance Foundation in India and abroad, she also anchors Reliance Foundation's work with children and women and RIL's diversity and inclusion programme. Apart from being part of the executive leadership teams at Reliance Retail, Reliance Jio and Reliance Foundation, she is in the leadership team that runs the Dhirubhai Ambani International School. And the reliance on Isha's leadership is only rising. ■

–M.G. Arun

ACCOMPLISHMENT

She leads Reliance Retail, India's largest retailer by revenue, profit, reach and scale



Isha Ambani, *32*

Non-executive Director, Reliance Industries; Director, Reliance Retail

THE EXPANDING CHAIN

"We are delivering value to over 30 per cent of India's addressable population"

FAVOURITE MOMENTS Doting on her twins, Krishna and Aadiya, who turned one in November

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